ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

GST 107: Nigerian Peoples and Culture - Diversity, History and Nation-Building

The context every Nigerian graduate should be able to explain without slogans

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack organises Nigeria's pre-colonial societies, cultural institutions, colonial experience and post-independence challenges into clear themes you can actually remember. It replaces vague 'unity in diversity' answers with specific examples, dates and arguments.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Describe the political and social organisation of at least three pre-colonial Nigerian societies.
- Explain how colonialism reshaped Nigerian economies, identities and boundaries.
- Distinguish cultural relativism from ethnocentrism with Nigerian examples.
- Discuss national integration using evidence rather than slogans.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Peoples, cultures and the danger of stereotypes

Nigeria has more than 250 ethnic groups and over 500 languages. The three largest - Hausa-Fulani, Yoruba and Igbo - are often used as shorthand, but that shorthand hides enormous internal diversity.

Culture includes language, religion, food, dress, marriage, music, craft, political organisation and shared values. It is learned and changes over time; it is not biological.

Ethnocentrism judges another culture by the standards of one's own. Cultural relativism tries to understand a practice within its own context - without pretending that every practice is beyond criticism.

- Hausa city-states and the Sokoto Caliphate: centralised emirate administration, Islamic scholarship and trans-Saharan trade.
- Yoruba kingdoms: Ife and Oyo, divine kingship, the Oyo cavalry and a rich oral and artistic tradition.
- Igbo societies: largely acephalous village republics, age grades, title societies such as Ozo, and the Nri ritual complex.
- Minority and riverine peoples: the Tiv, Ijaw, Efik, Ibibio, Nupe, Kanuri and many others with distinct political systems.

Pre-colonial trade, craft and knowledge

Long before colonial boundaries, the area that became Nigeria had sophisticated economies and knowledge systems.

- Trans-Saharan trade linked Kano and Katsina to North Africa through leather, salt, kola and horses.
- The trans-Atlantic slave trade devastated communities and created wealth for intermediaries; its consequences outlasted abolition.
- Benin bronzes, Ife terracotta heads, Nok figures and Igbo-Ukwu bronzes show advanced metallurgy and artistry.
- Palm oil production, fishing, weaving, blacksmithing and salt making supported regional trade.
- Indigenous medicine, astronomy and agriculture were systems of knowledge, not mere superstition.

Colonialism and its long shadow

Colonial rule lasted roughly six decades but reorganised almost everything: boundaries, administration, economy, education and identity.

The 1884-85 Berlin Conference set the framework for European partition. The Royal Niger Company and later the British colonial administration merged protectorates in 1914 into a single entity.

Colonial economies were built around extraction - palm produce, cocoa, groundnuts, tin and later oil - with infrastructure designed to move goods to ports rather than connect Nigerian communities.

Indirect rule deepened some ethnic identities and created new administrative divisions. Mission schools produced a new elite that later led nationalist movements.

> **Exam precision**
> Do not write that 'the British united Nigeria'. They amalgamated territories for administrative convenience. The consequences - uneven development and contested citizenship - are still with us.

Nationalism, independence and nation-building

Nationalist movements used newspapers, unions, market associations and political parties to demand self-government.

- Early nationalism: Herbert Macaulay and the NNDP; the Aba Women's War of 1929 against colonial taxation.

- Mass nationalism: Nnamdi Azikiwe, Obafemi Awolowo, Ahmadu Bello and the parties they led.
- Independence in 1960; a republic in 1963; civil war from 1967 to 1970.
- Military rule alternated with short democratic periods until civilian rule returned in 1999.
- Federal character, state creation and revenue allocation are responses to the challenge of governing diversity.

> **Nation-building is not the same as unity**
> Unity is a condition; nation-building is the work of creating institutions and loyalties that make diversity governable. Cite specific institutions such as the NYSC, federal character and national language policy.

Peoples, not tribes

Nigeria has more than two hundred and fifty ethno-linguistic groups. The word "tribe" is avoided in serious scholarship because it implies a fixed, primitive unit and flattens enormous internal diversity; "ethnic group", "linguistic community" or a specific name such as "Igbo", "Yoruba", "Hausa", "Ibibio", "Tiv", "Ijaw" or "Nupe" is more accurate.

Even those names need care. "Igbo" covers communities with distinct dialects, political structures and histories; "Yoruba" as a unified identity is partly a nineteenth-century development shaped by missionaries, print and inter-city politics. Identity is layered: family, lineage, town, region, religion, occupation and generation all matter, and which layer is salient depends on the situation.

This matters for exam answers because the question "discuss Nigerian culture" invites a list of three groups and their festivals. A stronger answer explains how identities are constructed, how they change, and how they are mobilised politically.

Family, kinship and social organisation

Kinship organises rights and obligations: who inherits, who names a child, who buries whom, who may marry whom, and who is responsible when someone is in trouble. Patrilineal systems trace descent through men; matrilineal systems exist in parts of Nigeria and elsewhere; bilateral systems trace through both. Understanding which system operates in a community explains inheritance disputes, residence patterns and the authority of uncles and aunts.

Marriage in most Nigerian societies is a transaction between families, not only individuals. Bridewealth, which is not the same as bride price or wife purchase, formalises the alliance and gives the wife's family claims on the husband's lineage. Christian and Islamic marriage regimes coexist with customary marriage, and many families register more than one.

Age grades, title societies, secret associations and market women's associations are civic institutions with real power. A student who describes a community only through its festivals has missed the governance structures that actually run it.

> **Avoid the culture list**
> Festival, food, dress is description, not analysis. Ask instead: what does this practice do for the people who maintain it, and who benefits if it continues or changes?

Culture, change and the national question

Culture is not a museum object. Nigerian cultural practice has absorbed and reshaped Christianity, Islam, colonial administration, migration, Nollywood, the mobile phone and social media. A masquerade may now be recorded and posted; a traditional wedding may be planned on WhatsApp; a language may be revitalised through online content.

The national question - how a state of many nations should be governed, and whether the current federal arrangement distributes resources and power fairly - runs through Nigerian politics. Ethnic and religious identity are mobilised in competition for resources, which is why the study of culture cannot be separated from the study of political economy.

Language is the clearest index of both vitality and threat. Nigerian Pidgin functions as a national lingua franca with its own grammar and literature; Standard Nigerian English is an official variety, not a deviation; and smaller languages are losing speakers to urban migration and school language policy. Documenting a language is cultural work with a deadline.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Analysing a festival instead of describing it

You must write 500 words on a community festival. Build an analytical structure.

1. Name the community, the festival and the calendar point precisely.
2. Identify who authorises it: elders, priests, a titled society, a youth association.
3. Describe the phases and what each marks.
4. Explain the social functions: status display, dispute settlement, courtship, trade, commemoration.
5. Identify what has changed in living memory and who resisted the change.
6. Conclude on what the festival is doing now, not only what it once meant.

> **What to carry forward**
> Function and change turn description into analysis.

2. Handling the "three major ethnic groups" framing

An exam question assumes Nigeria has three ethnic groups. Answer it without reproducing the error.

1. Acknowledge the framing and its origin in colonial administration and national politics.
2. State the actual diversity: over 250 groups and more than 500 languages.
3. Explain why the triad persists: population, political weight, media representation.
4. Give examples of minority groups with distinct institutions.
5. Show the consequence: policy that assumes three groups marginalises others.
6. Conclude on the difference between a political shorthand and an accurate description.

> **What to carry forward**
> Correct a false premise in the question, then answer the question it was trying to ask.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain how kinship systems shape inheritance and residence in Nigerian communities.

15 marks

1. Define kinship and its functions.
2. Distinguish patrilineal, matrilineal and bilateral descent.
3. Trace one consequence for inheritance and one for residence.
4. Note the interaction with statutory and Islamic law.
5. Conclude on how descent systems produce different disputes.

Q2. Discuss the view that Nigerian culture is being eroded by globalisation.

20 marks

1. Clarify what "erosion" would mean and how it could be measured.
2. Give evidence of loss: language shift, declining participation, commodification.
3. Give evidence of adaptation: Nollywood, music, online language activism.
4. Explain the political economy: who profits from which cultural form.
5. Conclude that change is uneven rather than simple decline.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Treating change as loss. Some practices are abandoned because people choose to.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Ethnic group. A community sharing descent, language or culture, with internal diversity.

Kinship. Relations of descent and marriage that define rights and obligations.

Patrilineal. Tracing descent and inheritance through the male line.

Matrilineal. Tracing descent and inheritance through the female line.

Bridewealth. Goods or money transferred between families to formalise a marriage alliance.

Age grade. A cohort organised by age with defined duties and rights in the community.

Title society. An association conferring ranked status and authority within a community.

Lingua franca. A shared language used between speakers of different first languages.

Nigerian Pidgin. A widely spoken contact language with its own grammar and literature.

National question. The debate over how Nigeria's constituent nations should share power and resources.

Syncretism. The blending of beliefs and practices from different traditions.

Cultural commodification. Turning cultural practice into a product for sale, changing its meaning.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Peoples

Accurate categories.

- List ten ethnic groups and their locations.
- Explain why "tribe" is imprecise.
- Trace how Yoruba identity formed.

Week 2 - Institutions

Kinship and authority.

- Map one community's descent system.
- Identify three civic institutions.
- Explain bridewealth to a foreigner.

Week 3 - Culture

Practice and change.

- Analyse one festival by function.
- Record one change in living memory.
- Interview one elder about it.

Week 4 - Debate

The national question.

- Summarise the federalism debate.
- Take a position with evidence.
- Write a timed 20-mark answer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any Nigerian peoples and culture course text covering ethnic groups and institutions.
- A history of Nigeria covering pre-colonial states and colonial administration.
- Scholarship on Nigerian Pidgin and language policy.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is cultural relativism?

Answer: The view that a culture should be understood in terms of its own values and context rather than judged by the standards of another culture.

2. Name two features of pre-colonial Igbo political organisation.

Answer: Village assemblies and age-grade associations; title societies such as Ozo; and decentralised governance without a single paramount ruler in many communities.

3. Why was the 1914 amalgamation significant?

Answer: It joined the Northern and Southern Protectorates into one administrative unit, shaping the boundaries and governance structure of modern Nigeria.

4. Distinguish ethnocentrism from racism.

Answer: Ethnocentrism judges other cultures by one's own cultural standards. Racism asserts that racial groups have inherent superior or inferior qualities and often justifies discrimination.

5. Give one economic effect of colonial rule in Nigeria.

Answer: The economy was reorganised around export crops and mineral extraction for European markets, with infrastructure built mainly to move goods to ports.

6. What is federal character, and why is it controversial?

Answer: A constitutional principle requiring fair representation of Nigeria's diverse groups in public institutions. Critics argue it can undermine merit; supporters argue it protects inclusion in a deeply unequal federation.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Draw a map of Nigeria's six geopolitical zones and label three ethnic groups in each.
- [ ] Write one paragraph each on pre-colonial Hausa, Yoruba and Igbo political systems.
- [ ] Create a timeline from 1884 to 1999 with ten key events.
- [ ] Explain three ways colonialism changed Nigerian education and economy.
- [ ] Learn five cultural practices from groups outside your own without caricature.
- [ ] Write a balanced answer on whether Nigeria is a nation or merely a state.
- [ ] Discuss one current national issue using historical context rather than blame.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | GST & Compulsory Courses | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

GST 107: Nigerian Peoples and Culture - Diversity, History and Nation-Building